

Build Quantum Mechanics from Scratch

1 Introduction

We derive the Schrödinger equation of quantum mechanics from several basic experimental facts. These facts are treated as axioms. In fact, what we will get is a generalized Schrödinger equation, which is the most generic equation that these axioms can imply.

1.1 Conventions

- **Definitions** are in bold font.
- *Important* statements are in italic font.
- Only important equations are numbered.
- **Questions** are in red color.
- **Conclusions** are in green color.

1.2 Abbreviations

Because we are doing high-dimensional calculus, abbreviations are essential for not falling in the “debauchery of formulae”.

When $x, y \in \mathbb{R}^d$, denote $xy = x \cdot y = \sum_{\alpha} x^{\alpha} y^{\alpha}$. Thus, $x^2 = x \cdot x = \sum_{\alpha} (x^{\alpha})^2$. Furthermore, we use multi-dimensional index $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n)$ for abbreviating partial derivative $(\partial_{\alpha_1} \cdots \partial_{\alpha_n} f)(x)$ to $\partial_{\alpha}^n f(x)$, and abbreviating tensor (generalization of vector to multiple indices) $M^{\alpha_1 \cdots \alpha_n}$ to M^{α} . For example, the product $v^{\alpha_1} \cdots v^{\alpha_n}$ can be abbreviated as v^{α} .

Einstein’s convention of summation is an elegant abbreviation for high-dimensional calculus and tensor analysis. It neglects the Σ_{α} in $\sum_{\alpha} v_{\alpha} w^{\alpha}$, abbreviated to be $v_{\alpha} w^{\alpha}$. The indices are “balanced”, one superscript, and the other subscript. The convention does not apply to the “unbalanced” summation such as $\sum_{\alpha} v^{\alpha} w^{\alpha}$, because both indices are superscripts.

2 Probability Interpretation and Wavefunction

In classical Newtonian world, the states of a physical system with n particles are represented by elements in $\mathbb{R}^{6n}$, or **phases**, $3n$ dimensions for positions and $3n$ for velocities (or momenta). The time evolution is thus a trajectory in the phase space, namely a map $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{6n}$ (with time as the domain).

But for a quantum system, the states are represented by wavefunctions. A **wavefunction** is a map from the positions of particles, together with time, to complex plane. Thus, a wavefunction maps $\mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ where $d = 3n$. The first axiom claims how wavefunctions characterize a quantum system.

Axiom 1. *[Probability Interpretation] The states of a quantum system are represented by wavefunctions. And given a wavefunction φ , the probabilistic density that the particles are found in positions x at time t is given by $|\varphi(x, t)|^2 = \varphi^*(x, t)\varphi(x, t)$.*

3 Superposition Principle and Time Evolution

The second axiom of quantum mechanics, superposition principle, claims that operations on wavefunctions shall be linear (so that wavefunctions can be superpositioned).

Axiom 2. *[Superposition Principle] Physical laws that operate on quantum states shall be linear.*

An implication of superposition principle is how quantum states (precisely, their wavefunctions) evolve with time. Axiom 2 implies that the equation of time evolution (as a physical law that operates on a quantum state) shall be linear: $\partial\varphi/\partial t = L(\varphi)$ where the operation L is linear. Mathematically, linearity imports a kernel $r: \mathbb{R}^d \times \mathbb{R}^d \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ such that

$$i\frac{\partial\varphi}{\partial t}(x, t) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx r(x, y)\varphi(y, t). \quad (1)$$

The right hand side can be seen as a generalization of linear transformation in $\mathbb{R}^n$ like vector-matrix product $\sum_j r_{ij} \varphi_j$. The imaginary i is employed for convenience.

A direct result of axiom 1 is that probabilistic density shall be normalized. Namely, for any wave-function φ and any $t \in \mathbb{R}$, we shall have

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx \varphi^*(x, t) \varphi(x, t) = 1. \quad (2)$$

Taking derivative on t gives

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx \frac{\partial \varphi^*}{\partial t}(x, t) \varphi(x, t) + \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx \varphi^*(x, t) \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t}(x, t) = 0.$$

Replacing $(\partial \varphi / \partial t)$ by equation 1 (and its complex conjugation) gives

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy \varphi(x, t) [r^*(x, y) - r(y, x)] \varphi^*(y, t) = 0.$$

Since φ is arbitrary, we obtain

$$r^*(x, y) = r(y, x). \quad (3)$$

That is, complex conjugating r is simply swapping its arguments. We call such function **Hermi-tian**. The two arguments of r are not independent.

Probability interpretation (axiom 1), together with superposition principle (axiom 2), is the direct result of the double-slit experiment of electron. Details can be found in Feynman's Lectures on Physics, Vol 3, chapter 1.

4 Analytic Schwartz Space Is Dense in Square-Integrable Space

Before calculations, we first address where wavefunctions live. Probability interpretation (axiom 1) demands that wavefunctions are square-integrable. Namely, wavefunction is in the square-integrable space $L^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$. But this is far from sufficient. Many mathematical tools are essential for evaluating quantum mechanics. Two of the many are Fourier transform and Taylor series.

It is [well known](#), however, that the Fourier transform of a square-integrable function may not be square-integrable again, so that its inverse Fourier transform may not exist. Since Fourier transform is basic in quantum mechanics, we shall seek for a smaller space in which wavefunctions live. An ideal substitution is the (complex) Schwartz space. A **Schwartz space** $\mathcal{S}(\mathbb{R}^d)$ contains smooth function $f: \mathbb{R}^d \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ that decays “exponentially fast” at infinity. Precisely, for any m -order polynomial P_m and any m -order partial derivative ∂^n ,¹ with integers $m, n \geq 0$, we have

$$\lim_{\|x\| \rightarrow \infty} |P_m(x) \partial^n f(x)| = 0.$$

Functions in Schwartz space are usually termed as **Schwartz functions**. Fourier transform is an automorphism on Schwartz space. A function that is consistent with its Taylor series is analytical. It indicates that we shall further restrict the space of wavefunctions to **analytic Schwartz space**, denoted by $\mathcal{S}_A(\mathbb{R}^d)$, which collects all the analytic functions in Schwartz space $\mathcal{S}(\mathbb{R}^d)$.

For example, in traditional textures, solving the stationary Schrödinger equation of one-dimensional harmonic oscillator needs the expansion of wavefunction

$$\varphi(x) = \exp(-x^2) \left[\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} a_n x^n \right],$$

where the coefficients $(a_0, a_1, \dots)$ are to be determined. The factor $\exp(-x^2)$ is employed for an exponentially fast decay as $|x| \rightarrow \infty$ (thus φ is a Schwartz function). And the factor $[\dots]$ is a Taylor series. Hence, f is an analytic function in Schwartz space. The energy quantization emerges for ensuring the convergence of the series $\sum_n a_n x^n$.

1. For example, $\partial_\alpha \partial_\beta^2$ is 3-order partial derivative, and $\partial_\alpha \partial_\beta^2 \partial_\gamma^9$ is 12-order.

Analytic Schwartz functions are dense in square-integrable space, meaning that for any $f \in L^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$ and any $\varepsilon > 0$, there is a $g \in \mathcal{S}_A(\mathbb{R}^d)$ such that

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx |f(x) - g(x)|^2 < \varepsilon.$$

For example, for any wavefunction $f \in L^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$, when we measure the probability on any area of positions $U \subset \mathbb{R}^d$, we can use its approximation $g \in \mathcal{S}_A(\mathbb{R}^d)$ instead, because the difference is bounded by

$$\left| \int_U dx |f(x)|^2 - \int_U dx |g(x)|^2 \right| \leq \int_U dx |f(x) - g(x)|^2 \leq \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx |f(x) - g(x)|^2 < \varepsilon.$$

The first inequality is equivalent to $\|f\| - \|g\| \leq \|f - g\|$, where the norm is defined as $\|f\| := \int_U dx |f(x)|^2$, recognized as the L^2 -norm on U . It states that the difference between the two sides of a triangle is less than that of the third side. It is in this sense that the substitution $L^2(\mathbb{R}^d) \rightarrow \mathcal{S}_A(\mathbb{R}^d)$ is plausible. Proof of the statement that analytic Schwartz functions are dense in square-integrable space is given in appendices B and C.

Can we approximate the kernel such that $r \in \mathcal{S}_A(\mathbb{R}^{2d})$?

5 Path Integral Formalism

We are trying to derive a generic path integral formalism. Given a small $\Delta t > 0$, equation 1 gives

$$\varphi(x, t) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy [\delta(x - y) - i r(x, y) \Delta t] \varphi(y, t - \Delta t) + o(\Delta t)$$

We are to convert the $[\dots]$ part into exponential. To do so, we take the inverse Fourier transform

$$\delta(x - y) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(x - y)),$$

and

$$r(x, y) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(x - y)) \hat{r}(x, k), \quad (4)$$

in which^{2 3}

$$\hat{r}(x, k) := \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy \exp(-ik(x - y)) r(x, y). \quad (5)$$

². Indeed, by inserting equation 5 into equation 4, we get

$$r(x, y) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(x - y)) \times \left[\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy' \exp(-ik(x - y')) r(x, y') \right].$$

Re-arrange the right hand side as

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy' r(x, y') \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(y' - y)) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy' r(x, y') \delta(y' - y),$$

which goes back to $r(x, y)$, indicating that equations 4 and 5 are consistent.

³. We can also define

$$\hat{r}'(k, y) := \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx \exp(-ik(x - y)) r(x, y).$$

Thus,

$$r(x, y) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(x - y)) \hat{r}'(k, y).$$

Indeed, by plugging $\hat{r}'(k, y)$ into the right hand side of $r(x, y)$,

$$r(x, y) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(x - y)) \times \left[\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx' \exp(-ik(x' - y)) r(x', y) \right].$$

Re-arrange the right hand side as

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx' r(x', y) \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(x - x')) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx' r(x', y) \delta(x - x'),$$

which goes back to $r(x, y)$. The $\hat{r}$ and $\hat{r}'$ are the Fourier transform of r performed on each of its arguments. But, as we will see in section 6, only $\hat{r}$ is relevant to the moments of kernel (thus to Schrödinger's equation).

Then, the $[\cdot \cdot \cdot]$ part is converted into exponential by

$$\begin{aligned} [\cdot \cdot \cdot] &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp(ik(x-y)) [1 - i\hat{r}(x, k)\Delta t] \\ &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp\{ik(x-y) - i\hat{r}(x, k)\Delta t\} + o(\Delta t) \end{aligned}$$

Plugging back to $\varphi(x, t)$ results in

$$\varphi(x, t) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk}{(2\pi)^d} \exp\{ik(x-y) - i\hat{r}(x, k)\Delta t\} \varphi(y, t - \Delta t) + o(\Delta t)$$

After re-denoting $x_N := x$, $x_{N-1} := y$, $k_N := k$, it becomes

$$\varphi(x_N, t) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx_{N-1} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk_N}{(2\pi)^d} \exp\{ik_N(x_N - x_{N-1}) - i\hat{r}(x_N, k_N)\Delta t\} \varphi(x_{N-1}, t - \Delta t) + o(\Delta t).$$

Recursively applying to the rightmost φ factor (for example, the next step is applying to the $\varphi(x_{N-1}, t)$ factor) N times, we arrive at

$$\varphi(x_N, t) = \int D(x, k) \exp(iS(x, k)) \varphi(x_0, t - N\Delta t) + o(\Delta t), \quad (6)$$

where the integral

$$\int D(x, k) := \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx_{N-1} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk_N}{(2\pi)^d} \cdots \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx_0 \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dk_1}{(2\pi)^d} \quad (7)$$

and

$$S(k, x) := \sum_{i=1}^N \Delta t \left[k_i \left(\frac{x_i - x_{i-1}}{\Delta t} \right) - \hat{r}(x_i, k_i) \right]. \quad (8)$$

If we recognize $(x_i - x_{i-1})/\Delta t$ as the velocity $\dot{x}_i$, then the $S(x, k)$ can be seen as the Legendre transform $\dot{x}p - H(x, p)$, in which *k is analogy to momentum p and $\hat{r}(x, k)$ plays the role of Hamiltonian $H(x, p)$.*

6 Expanding Kernel as Generalized Function

Given any “test function” $\varphi \in \mathcal{S}_A(\mathbb{R}^d)$, Taylor expanding φ at x makes

$$\int dy r(x, y) \varphi(y) = \int dy r(x, y) \left[\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n!} \partial_{\alpha}^n \varphi(x) (y-x)^{\alpha} \right],$$

where $\alpha := (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n)$ and $(y-x)^{\alpha} := (y-x)^{\alpha_1} \cdots (y-x)^{\alpha_n}$ (recall the abbreviations). It is then re-arranged to

$$\sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n!} \partial_{\alpha}^n \varphi(x) \int dy r(x, y) (y-x)^{\alpha} = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} \partial_{\alpha}^n \varphi(x) \int dy r(x, y) (x-y)^{\alpha}.$$

Define the **moment**

$$R_n^{\alpha}(x) := \int dy r(x, y) (x-y)^{\alpha}. \quad (9)$$

Then, it becomes

$$\int dy r(x, y) \varphi(y) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} R_n^{\alpha}(x) \partial_{\alpha}^n \varphi(x).$$

Inserting the identity

$$\partial_{\alpha}^n \varphi(x) = \int dy \delta(x-y) \partial_{\alpha}^n \varphi(y)$$

to the right hand side gives

$$\int dy r(x, y) \varphi(y) = \int dy \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} R_n^\alpha(x) \delta(x-y) \partial_\alpha^n \varphi(y).$$

By integration by parts and noticing the parity of $\partial^n \delta$ (it is odd when n is odd, and even when n is even), we get

$$\int dy r(x, y) \varphi(y) = \int dy \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} R_n^\alpha(x) \partial_\alpha^n \delta(x-y) \varphi(y).$$

Since φ is arbitrary, we get

$$r(x, y) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} R_n^\alpha(x) \partial_\alpha^n \delta(x-y). \quad (10)$$

It shall be read as a formal expansion, or an “algorithm” (with which we obtain a valid expression of $\int dx f(x) \varphi(x)$). Only by applying to an analytic Schwartz function can it make sense. It claims that the kernel r , thus the time evolution of wavefunction (equation 1), is completely determined by the moments R_n s.

Plugging equation 10 back to equation 1 gives

$$i \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t}(x, t) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy R_n^\alpha(x) \partial_\alpha^n \delta(x-y) \varphi(y, t).$$

Then, after integration by parts and applying the parity of $\partial^n \delta$, we integrate over y , resulting in

$$i \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t}(x, t) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} \partial_\alpha^n [R_n^\alpha(x) \varphi(x, t)]. \quad (11)$$

This is a quantum analogy to the Kramers-Moyal expansion in stochastic process.

Interestingly, the Taylor expansion of the “Hamiltonian” $\hat{r}(x, k)$, defined by equation 5, also relates to the moments R_n s. Directly by equation 5, we have

$$\frac{\partial^n \hat{r}}{\partial k_\alpha^n}(x, 0) = \lim_{k \rightarrow 0} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy \left[\frac{\partial^n}{\partial k_\alpha^n} \exp(-ik(x-y)) \right] r(x, y) = (-i)^n \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy r(x, y) (x-y)^\alpha.$$

The integral is recognized as $R_n^\alpha(x)$. So, we find $(-i)^n R_n^\alpha(x)$ s the Taylor coefficients of $\hat{r}(x, k)$ expanded by k at its origin. Namely,

$$\hat{r}(x, k) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-i)^n}{n!} R_n^\alpha(x) k_\alpha, \quad (12)$$

where $k_\alpha := (k_{\alpha_1} \cdots k_{\alpha_n})$. Again, the details of $S(x, k)$ can be completely determined by the moments R_n s.

So, consider the traditional Hamiltonian $\hat{r}(x, p) = p^2/(2m) + V(x)$, all R_n s vanish except for $R_0(x) = V(x)$ and $R_2(x) = -1/m$. Equation 10 implies

$$r(x, y) = V(x) \delta(y-x) - \frac{1}{2m} \nabla^2 \delta(y-x).$$

Then equation 1 becomes (after integration by parts and omitting the boundary term)

$$i \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t}(x, t) = \int_{\mathbb{R}} dy \varphi(y, t) \left[V(x) \delta(y-x) - \frac{1}{2m} \nabla^2 \delta(y-x) \right] = -\frac{1}{2m} \nabla^2 \varphi(x, t) + V(x) \varphi(x, t),$$

which is exactly the Schrödinger equation.

7 Locality Truncates the Moments

We then introduce the third axiom about locality, and discuss what it will induce.

Axiom 3. *[Locality] Time evolution of quantum system is local.*

Shall not confuse time evolution with collapse, which is proven to be non-local. Axiom 3 claims that equation 1 is local. To make this clear, we consider an example, in which $R_n(x) = c^n$ for some constant c , and set the dimension $d = 1$ for simplicity. Then, time evolution (equation 11) at $x = 0$ is

$$i\frac{\partial\varphi}{\partial t}(0, t) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-c)^n}{n!} \frac{\partial^n \varphi}{\partial x^n}(0, t).$$

The last expression happens to be the Taylor series of $\varphi(x, t)$ at $x = -c$, namely $\varphi(-c, t)$. So, we conclude that $R_n(x) = c^n$ for some constant c implies

$$i\frac{\partial\varphi}{\partial t}(0, t) = \varphi(-c, t).$$

If we change the value of φ at $x = -c$, then the time evolution at $x = 0$ changes accordingly. It means non-locality.

In physics, a local equation generally refers to an operation on φ which contains φ itself and *finite* number of spatial derivatives of φ , such as

$$i\frac{\partial\varphi}{\partial t}(x, t) = \mathcal{L}\left(\varphi(x, t), \frac{\partial\varphi}{\partial x}(x, t), \frac{\partial^2\varphi}{\partial x^2}(x, t), \dots, \frac{\partial^n\varphi}{\partial x^n}(x, t)\right),$$

where $\mathcal{L}$ is an analytic function. This is easy to understand because to compute $(\partial^n\varphi/\partial x^n)(0, t)$ using numerical method with difference Δx , only $\varphi(x, t)$ with $x \in \{0, \Delta x, \dots, n\Delta x\}$ are employed.⁴ So, $(\partial\varphi/\partial t)(0, t)$ cannot “perceive” the $\varphi(x, t)$ outside the neighborhood $\{x: |x| \leq n\Delta x\}$. Since Δx can be arbitrarily small (but not vanishing), the equation is local.

We have shown that, with a cut-off N_{cut} on R_n s such that $R_n = 0$ for any $n > N_{\text{cut}}$, time evolution of wavefunction is local. And without such a cut-off, we can construct a sequence of R_n s such that time evolution is not local. Now, we are to prove that, generally, without a cut-off, any sequence of R_n s (such that for any $N > 0$, there are infinite many R_n s that are not vanishing), time evolution of wavefunction is non-local. This then imports a cut-off on moments.

Before proving, we first declare a property of analytic function. Consider the Taylor expansion of $\varphi \in \mathcal{S}_A(\mathbb{R})$ at origin

$$\varphi(x) = a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + \dots$$

The information of φ is completely encoded in the infinite sequence of a_n s. This is the result of a theorem which claims that two analytic functions are equal if they agree in any interval (hence we can obtain the Taylor series of the function within the interval). What if we only know a portion of the infinite sequence of a_n s? For example, if we only know the a_0 , then only the value of $\varphi(x)$ at $x = 0$ is determined. Further, if we also know the a_1 , then we can give a good approximation to $\varphi(x)$ in a very tiny neighborhood at $x = 0$, since $\varphi(x) = a_0 + a_1x + o(x^2)$. Then, if we additionally know the a_2 , then the approximation becomes as good as before in a larger neighborhood at $x = 0$, since $\varphi(x) = a_0 + a_1x + a_2x^2 + o(x^3)$ and the size of neighborhood can increase a little without growing the scale of residue. This analysis indicates that the more a_n s we know, in a larger neighborhood at $x = 0$ can we properly approximate $\varphi(x)$. Our vision becomes border and border if we know more and more a_n s. Until knowing the whole sequence of a_n s, we realize the complete picture of $\varphi(x)$ (based on the previous theorem about analytic function).

It also indicates that, for a sufficient large N , we can keep $\varphi(x)$ (approximately) invariant when we tune the a_n s with $n > N$ while keeping the other a_n s unchanged. On the other hand, based on the equation (plugging $\varphi(x) = \sum_n a_n x^n$ into equation 11, and collecting all a_m terms with $m < n$ into $[\dots]$),

$$i\frac{\partial\varphi}{\partial t}(0, t) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \{[\dots] + (-1)^n R_n(0)a_n\},$$

4. Given a smooth function f , numerically evaluating $f^{(n)}(0)$ needs $f^{(n-1)}(0)$ and $f^{(n-1)}(\Delta x)$. Recursively, numerically evaluating $f^{(n-1)}(0)$ needs $f^{(n-2)}(0)$ and $f^{(n-2)}(\Delta x)$, and $f^{(n-1)}(\Delta x)$ needs $f^{(n-2)}(\Delta x)$ and $f^{(n-2)}(2\Delta x)$. Repeating this process, we find $\{f(0), \dots, f(n\Delta x)\}$ are needed for evaluating $f^{(n)}(0)$.

if there is not a cut-off to the infinite sequence of $R_n(0)$ s, we can modify the $(\partial\varphi/\partial t)(0, t)$ by tuning an a_n where n can be arbitrarily large. This, however, will leave the $\varphi(x)$ around $x=0$ invariant. It means that the value of φ with x far away from $x=0$ can affect the time evolution of φ at $x=0$. That is, time evolution of wavefunction is non-local. Hence, there must be a cut-off on the sequence of $R_n(0)$ s. This discussion also holds for any value of x other than $x=0$. We conclude that *time evolution is local if and only if there is a positive integer N_{cut} such that $R_n=0$ for any $n > N_{\text{cut}}$* .

8 Hermitianity on the Moments of Transition Rate

Now we study the relation between R_n s and their complex conjugations. By conjugating equation 5 and applying the Hermitianity of r , we get

$$\hat{r}^*(x, k) := \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dy \exp(ik(x-y)) r(y, x).$$

Then, applying equation 4 to $r(y, x)$ gives

$$\hat{r}^*(x, k) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dk' \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dy}{(2\pi)^d} \exp\{i(k-k')(x-y)\} \hat{r}(y, k').$$

Taylor expanding $\hat{r}(y, k')$ by y at x ,

$$\hat{r}^*(x, k) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n!} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dk' \frac{\partial^n \hat{r}}{\partial x^\alpha}(x, k') \times \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dy}{(2\pi)^d} \exp\{i(k-k')(x-y)\} (y-x)^\alpha.$$

Noticing that

$$\frac{\partial^n \delta}{\partial k'_\alpha}(k' - k) = \frac{\partial^n}{\partial k'_\alpha} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dy}{(2\pi)^d} \exp\{i(k' - k)(y - x)\} = i^n \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \frac{dy}{(2\pi)^d} \exp\{i(k' - k)(y - x)\} (y - x)^\alpha.$$

the last integral in $\hat{r}^*(x, k)$ is evaluated to be $(-i)^n \partial_\alpha^n \delta(k' - k)$. Thus,

$$\hat{r}^*(x, k) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-i)^n}{n!} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dk' \frac{\partial^n \hat{r}}{\partial x^\alpha}(x, k') \frac{\partial^n \delta}{\partial k'_\alpha}(k' - k).$$

Then, by integration by parts and then integrating over k' , we arrive at

$$\hat{r}^*(x, k) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{i^n}{n!} \frac{\partial^{2n} \hat{r}}{\partial x^\alpha \partial k_\alpha}(x, k). \quad (13)$$

Since $(-i)^n R_n(x)$ s are the coefficients of Taylor expansion of $\hat{r}(x, k)$ by k (equation 12), we find

$$\begin{aligned} (R_m^\alpha)^*(x) &= (-i)^m \frac{\partial^m \hat{r}^*}{\partial k_\alpha}(x, 0) \\ &= (-i)^m \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{i^n}{n!} \frac{\partial^n}{\partial x^\beta} \frac{\partial^{m+n} \hat{r}}{\partial k_\alpha \partial k_\beta}(x, 0) \\ &= (-i)^m \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{i^n}{n!} \frac{\partial^n}{\partial x^\beta} [(-i)^{m+n} R_{m+n}^{\alpha\beta}(x)] \\ &= (-1)^m \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{n!} \partial_\beta^n R_{m+n}^{\alpha\beta}(x). \end{aligned}$$

Recall that $R_n=0$ for any $n > N_{\text{cut}}$, we finally get

$$(R_m^\alpha)^*(x) = (-1)^m \sum_{n=0}^{N_{\text{cut}}-m} \frac{1}{n!} \partial_\beta^n R_{m+n}^{\alpha\beta}(x). \quad (14)$$

For example, when $N_{\text{cut}} = 2$, we have

$$R_0^*(x) = R_0(x) + \partial_\alpha R_1^\alpha(x) + \frac{1}{2} \partial_\alpha^2 R_2^\alpha(x),$$

$$(R_1^\alpha)^*(x) = -R_1^\alpha(x) - \partial_\beta R_2^{\alpha\beta}(x),$$

and

$$(R_2^\alpha)^*(x) = R_2^\alpha(x),$$

that is, R_2 is real. Specially, we have

$$R_{N_{\text{cut}}}^*(x) = (-1)^{N_{\text{cut}}} R_{N_{\text{cut}}}(x).$$

That is, $R_{N_{\text{cut}}}$ is real when N_{cut} is even, otherwise purely imaginary.

9 Uncertainty Principle Restricts the Highest Order Moment

An **observable** is a real function of the particle positions of a quantum system, such as $F: \mathbb{R}^d \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ for some positive integer n . A corollary of axiom 1 is that, given a wavefunction φ and an observable F , $|\varphi(x, t)|^2$ represents the probability density that the particles are found on positions x at time t , hence the observed value is the expectation

$$\mathbb{E}_\varphi[F](t) := \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx |\varphi(x, t)|^2 F(x). \quad (15)$$

And the variance

$$\text{Var}_\varphi[F](t) := \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx |\varphi(x, t)|^2 [F(x) - \mathbb{E}_\varphi[F](t)]^2. \quad (16)$$

For a single particle system, we use X to denote the position of the particle, thus a with $X(x) = x$. The uncertainty of position is given by

$$\Delta X(t) := \sqrt{\text{Var}_\varphi[X](t)}. \quad (17)$$

Having observed the particle position at time t and $t + \Delta t$ subsequently, we can obtain the velocity of the particle

$$V(t) := \lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \frac{\mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](t + \Delta t) - \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](t)}{\Delta t}. \quad (18)$$

The uncertainty of velocity is hard to determine, because of ends (particle positions at time t and $t + \Delta t$) are uncertain. The key is fixing the position at time t by $\mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](t)$, and measuring the uncertainty caused by the position at time $t + \Delta t$, that is, *the uncertainty induced by time evolution*. Having considered thus, we have

$$\Delta V(t) := \sqrt{\lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \text{Var}_\varphi \left[\frac{X - \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](t)}{\Delta t} \right] (t + \Delta t)}. \quad (19)$$

Have clarified the uncertainties of particle position and velocity, we can claim uncertainty principle as follow.

Axiom 4. *[Uncertainty Principle of Single Particle] In a single particle quantum system, given a wavefunction φ , the uncertainties of position and of velocity have the relation*

$$\Delta X(t) \Delta V(t) \sim \hbar / (2m),$$

where m is the mass of the particle, and $\hbar$ is the reduced Planck's constant.

In the rest of this section, we investigate how uncertainty principle restricts further to the kernel. We first deal with the situation where dimension $d = 1$. Since axiom 4 holds for all wavefunctions of a single particle, we choose φ to be Gaussian at $t = 0$, that is

$$\varphi(x, 0) = (2\pi\sigma^2)^{-1/4} \exp\left(-\frac{x^2}{4\sigma^2}\right). \quad (20)$$

The coefficient guarantees the normalization of φ . By axiom 1, we have

$$\mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](0) := \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \varphi^*(x, 0) \varphi(x, 0) x = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi\sigma^2}} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx \exp\left(-\frac{x^2}{2\sigma^2}\right) x = 0,$$

then

$$\text{Var}_\varphi[X](0) := \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \varphi^*(x, 0) \varphi(x, 0) x^2 = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi\sigma^2}} \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} dx \exp\left(-\frac{x^2}{2\sigma^2}\right) x^2 = \sigma^2.$$

To evaluate $\Delta V(0)$, we have to use time evolution equation to calculate X at time Δt . By equation 1, we have (for brevity, we omit the subscript cut in N_{cut})

$$\varphi(x, \Delta t) = \varphi(x, 0) - i\Delta t \sum_{n=0}^N \frac{(-1)^n}{n!} \partial^n [R_n(x) \varphi(x, 0)] - \frac{i}{2} \Delta t^2 \sum_{n=0}^N \sum_{n'=0}^N \dots$$

We have to evaluate up to $o(\Delta t^2)$, so as to give the variance of velocity which scales as $x^2(\Delta t)/\Delta t^2$. But this would be too complicated (the double summation). For simplification, we consider a “free particle” where all R_n s but the R_N are vanishing. This is the situation when σ tends to zero, because there are more σ factors in the denominator if there are more derivatives on f , and as σ tends to zero, the term proportional to $R_N(x) \partial^N [f(x, 0)]$ surpasses all the other terms.⁵ In this situation, equation 1 reduces to

$$i \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t}(x, t) = \frac{(-1)^N}{N!} R_N(x) \partial^N \varphi(x, t).$$

Hence, up to $o(\Delta t^2)$ (we will see why $o(\Delta t)$ is insufficient),

$$\begin{aligned} \varphi(x, \Delta t) &= \varphi(x, 0) + \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t}(x, 0) \Delta t + \frac{1}{2} \frac{\partial^2 \varphi}{\partial t^2}(x, 0) \Delta t^2 + o(\Delta t^2) \\ &= \varphi(x, 0) - i \frac{(-1)^N}{N!} R_N(x) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) \Delta t - \frac{i}{2} \frac{(-1)^N}{N!} R_N(x) \partial^N \frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial t}(x, 0) \Delta t^2 + o(\Delta t^2). \end{aligned}$$

Inserting $(\partial \varphi / \partial t)$ and considering $\sigma \rightarrow 0$ again, we get

$$\varphi(x, \Delta t) = \varphi(x, 0) - i \frac{(-1)^N}{N!} R_N(x) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) \Delta t - \frac{1}{2} \left[\frac{(-1)^N}{N!} R_N(x) \right]^2 \partial^{2N} \varphi(x, 0) \Delta t^2 + o(\Delta t^2).$$

Having obtained $\varphi(x, \Delta t)$, now we evaluate $\text{Var}_\varphi[V](0)$. First, we evaluate $V(0)$ as

$$V(0) = \lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \mathbb{E}_\varphi \left[\frac{X - \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](0)}{\Delta t} \right] (\Delta t) = \lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \frac{\mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](\Delta t) - \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](0)}{\Delta t}.$$

Directly inserting $\varphi(x, \Delta t)$ results in

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](\Delta t) &= \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx |\varphi(x, \Delta t)|^2 x \\ &= \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](0) + i \frac{(-1)^N}{N!} \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \varphi(x, 0) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) [R_N^*(x) - R_N(x)] x \Delta t + o(\Delta t). \end{aligned}$$

Hence,

$$V(0) = i \frac{(-1)^N}{N!} \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \varphi(x, 0) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) [R_N^*(x) - R_N(x)] x.$$

When N is even, R_N is real (see section 8), we find $V(0) = 0$. But when N is odd, R_N is purely imaginary. In this situation, denote $R_N(x) = iA(x)/2$, we get

$$V(0) = \frac{(-1)^N}{N!} \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \varphi(x, 0) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) A(x) x,$$

⁵ In the traditional approach of quantum mechanics, $\sigma \rightarrow 0$ indicates that the momentum is large (since momentum is proportional to $\partial/\partial x$), so the term with the highest order of momentum will dominates the time evolution. When the momentum is large enough, the kinetic term dominates Hamiltonian, the potential becomes omittable, making the particle free (namely, unconstrained by potential).

which may not vanish, leading to a violation of parity symmetry, because the velocity has a favored direction even though the distribution (or wavefunction) has not. So, from now on, we only consider when N is even. For any random variable R , we have the formula $\text{Var}[R] = \mathbb{E}[R^2] - \mathbb{E}^2[R]$. Then, we find (recall that $\mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](0) = V(0) = 0$ when N is even)

$$\Delta V^2(0) = \lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \mathbb{E}_\varphi \left[\left(\frac{X - \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X](0)}{\Delta t} \right)^2 \right] (\Delta t) - V^2(0) = \lim_{\Delta t \rightarrow 0} \frac{\mathbb{E}_\varphi[X^2](\Delta t)}{\Delta t^2}.$$

Since R_N has been real, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}_\varphi[X^2](\Delta t) &= \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \varphi^*(x, \Delta t) \varphi(x, \Delta t) x^2 \\ &= \left(\frac{1}{N!} \right)^2 \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \left[\partial^N \varphi(x, 0) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) - \frac{1}{2} \varphi(x, 0) \partial^{2N} \varphi(x, 0) \right] R_N^2(x) x^2 \Delta t^2 + o(\Delta t^2). \end{aligned}$$

So,

$$\Delta V^2(0) = \left(\frac{1}{N!} \right)^2 \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \left[\partial^N \varphi(x, 0) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) - \frac{1}{2} \varphi(x, 0) \partial^{2N} \varphi(x, 0) \right] R_N^2(x) x^2.$$

As we have expected, the terms that involve the partial derivatives of φ share the same (highest) order of $1/\sigma$, surpassing all the terms that we have neglected (which have lower order of $1/\sigma$) as σ tends to zero. Assume that R_N is analytic, so that we can Taylor expand R_N^2 at origin, as

$$R_N^2(x) = R_N^2(0) + \partial R_N^2(0)x + \frac{1}{2} \partial^2 R_N^2(0)x^2 + \dots$$

We arrive at

$$\Delta V^2(0) = \left(\frac{1}{N!} \right)^2 \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} \frac{\partial^n R_N^2(0)}{n!} \int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \left[\partial^N \varphi(x, 0) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) - \frac{1}{2} \varphi(x, 0) \partial^{2N} \varphi(x, 0) \right] x^{2+n}. \quad (21)$$

With the aid of computer, we evaluate the term in $\Delta V^2(0)$ for each N and n (see appendix D. To satisfy uncertainty principle (axiom 4), $\Delta V^2(0)$ shall be proportional to $1/\sigma^2$, so that $\Delta X \Delta V$ is independent of σ . Such terms are found when $(N, n) \in \{(2, 0), (4, 4), (6, 8), (8, 12), \dots\}$, indicating a relation $n = 4(N/2 - 1) = 2N - 4$. So, we have $\partial^n R_N^2(0) = 0$ except for $n = 2N - 4$. In other words,

$$R_N(x) \propto x^{N-2}. \quad (22)$$

The specific case is $N = 2$ in which R_N becomes constant. This is the canonical situation in physics. So, uncertainty principle restricts the highest order moment to be an explicit power function.

We can generalize the previous analysis to dimension $d > 1$, in which the covariance matrix of f is diagonal, such that all dimensions are independent. Namely,

$$\varphi(x, 0) = \prod_{\alpha=1}^d (2\pi(\sigma^\alpha)^2)^{-1/4} \exp\left(-\frac{1}{4} \left(\frac{x^\alpha}{\sigma^\alpha}\right)^2\right).$$

The previous analysis, then, is taken on each dimension individually, resulting in exactly the same result for each dimension.

Appendix A

Taylor Reminder

Given a function $f \in \mathcal{C}^n(\mathbb{R}^d)$, we are to calculate the reminder $h_n(x, x_0)$ in the Taylor expansion at x_0

$$f(x) = f(x_0) + \sum_{k=1}^n \frac{1}{k!} (\partial_{\alpha_1} \cdots \partial_{\alpha_k} f)(x_0) \prod_{i=1}^k (x^{\alpha_i} - x_0^{\alpha_i}) + h_{n+1}(x, x_0).$$

We begin at a variation of the fundamental theorem of calculus

$$f(x) - f(x_0) = \int_0^1 dt (\partial_{\alpha_1} f)(x + t(x_0 - x))(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1}).$$

Integration by parts gives

$$f(x) - f(x_0) = (\partial_{\alpha_1} f)(x_0)(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1}) + \frac{1}{2} \int_0^1 dt^2 (\partial_{\alpha_1} \partial_{\alpha_2} f)(x + t(x_0 - x))(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1})(x^{\alpha_2} - x_0^{\alpha_2}).$$

Applying integration by parts on the integral again, we get

$$\begin{aligned} f(x) - f(x_0) &= (\partial_{\alpha_1} f)(x_0)(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1}) \\ &\quad + \frac{1}{2!} (\partial_{\alpha_1} \partial_{\alpha_2} f)(x_0)(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1})(x^{\alpha_2} - x_0^{\alpha_2}) \\ &\quad + \frac{1}{3!} \int_0^1 dt^3 (\partial_{\alpha_1} \partial_{\alpha_2} \partial_{\alpha_3} f)(x + t(x_0 - x))(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1})(x^{\alpha_2} - x_0^{\alpha_2})(x^{\alpha_3} - x_0^{\alpha_3}). \end{aligned}$$

Repeating this process gives

$$\begin{aligned} f(x) - f(x_0) &= (\partial_{\alpha_1} f)(x_0)(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1}) \\ &\quad + \frac{1}{2!} (\partial_{\alpha_1} \partial_{\alpha_2} f)(x_0)(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1})(x^{\alpha_2} - x_0^{\alpha_2}) \\ &\quad + \cdots \\ &\quad + \frac{1}{n!} \int_0^1 dt^n (\partial_{\alpha_1} \cdots \partial_{\alpha_n} f)(x + t(x_0 - x))(x^{\alpha_1} - x_0^{\alpha_1}) \cdots (x^{\alpha_n} - x_0^{\alpha_n}). \end{aligned}$$

So, the Taylor reminder reads

$$h_n(x, x_0) = \frac{1}{n!} \prod_{i=1}^n (x^{\alpha_i} - x_0^{\alpha_i}) \times \int_0^1 dt^n (\partial_{\alpha_1} \cdots \partial_{\alpha_n} f)(x + t(x_0 - x)). \quad (\text{A.1})$$

Appendix B

Schwartz Functions are Dense in Square-Integrable Space

Appendix C

Analytic Functions are Dense in Schwartz Space

Appendix D

Computing the Uncertainty of Velocity

We use Wolfram Mathematica to compute the integral in equation 21. Namely, given (N, n) , we are to evaluate

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}} dx \left[\partial^N \varphi(x, 0) \partial^N \varphi(x, 0) - \frac{1}{2} \varphi(x, 0) \partial^{2N} \varphi(x, 0) \right] x^{2+n},$$

where φ is given by equation 20. In Mathematica, we first input φ (re-denoted by f) as

```
f[x_, sigma_] := (2*Pi*sigma^2)^(-1/4)*Exp[-x^2/4/sigma^2];
```

Then, input the target integral as

```
targetIntegral[sigma_, N_, n_] := Simplify[Integrate[(D[f[x, sigma], {x, N}]^2 - f[x, sigma]* D[f[x, sigma], {x, 2*N}] / 2) * x^(n+2), {x, -Infinity, Infinity}, Assumptions->{Element[sigma, Reals]}]];
```

where we have to assert that `sigma` is a real number. Then, we try (we have to re-denote N by `m` because `N` has been a keyword of Mathematica)

```
Table[{m, n}, targetIntegral[sigma, m, n]], {m, {2, 4, 6, 8}}, {n, 0, 15}]
```

which outputs the (N, n) pairs and the corresponding integrals.